



Aardling brand guide

Version 0.8.0

Software strategy, architecture, and domain modelling in complex environments.

Generated from [@aardling/brand-aardling](#) at version 0.8.0. The package is the source of truth; this document is a view of it.

What this is

Everything Aardling puts in front of a reader is built from one package. This document is that package, printed.

The rules here are not preferences. Each was decided against something measured — a contrast ratio, a rendered mark at 16px, a heading at half a gradient's width. Where this guide states a number, the number came from a test.

Follow it when you are asked to make an exception. The exceptions that exist are already in here; the ones that are not in here are not exceptions.

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Each section maps to a file in the package's **guidelines/** directory, named in the top right of every page. Where this printed guide condenses, that file is the longer answer — and where the two disagree, the file wins.

Aardling

Capital A, the rest lower case, one word. There is no second accepted form.

In headlines, in body copy, in navigation, in email, in decks, in social posts, and in a sentence that begins with it. In prose, never *aardling*, never **AARDLING**, never *AardLing*.

Machine identifiers stay lower case

npm does not accept a capital in a scope, and mixed-case paths break on case-sensitive filesystems. The spelling rule governs words a reader sees set as text; it does not govern identifiers.

```
@aardling/brand-aardling  
aardling/ aardling-brand --  
colour-* aardling.eu
```

The logotype is drawn, not spelled

The mark sets AARDLING in capitals with the double-A ligature. That is lettering. It is not permission to set the name in capitals anywhere else — not in a heading, not in a navigation item, not in a slide title.



The mark and the word are not the same thing

The mark on the left is a drawing. The word beside it is text. A slide that carries both carries **AARDLING** once, as artwork, and **Aardling** everywhere the reader reads.

The brand name stands alone

Four legal entities exist. Use one only where the law or an accountant needs it: an imprint, a contract, an invoice, terms and conditions, a privacy policy, a VAT line. An entity name never appears in a headline, a deck, a byline or body copy.

YES

Aardling ran the
modelling workshop.

NO

Aardling BV ran the
modelling workshop.

Registered addresses

Canonical. Transcribe the street lines exactly. Place names take their English form where one exists, which is why these read Antwerp and not Antwerpen; Hoorn and Lille have none and are unchanged. Aardling BV and Aardling Belgium BV share a building and differ only by bus number.

Aardling BV

Tabakvest 87 bus 4761
2000 Antwerp
Belgium

Aardling Belgium BV

Tabakvest 87 bus 4762
2000 Antwerp
Belgium

Aardling Netherlands BV

DTG Accountants
Postbus 2131
1620 EC Hoorn
Netherlands

Aardling France SAS

10 Rue Michel Servet
59000 Lille
France

An address appears only where an entity name does. Registration and VAT numbers are not carried in the package: take those from the register or from finance.

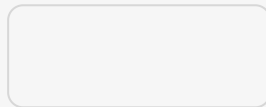
Seven brand colours, four functional

The brand colours come from the original brand guide. The functional colours were in the website's CSS without ever having been approved, and are kept because each does a job the brand colours cannot.

BRAND

**Night Blue**

#181C2F

**Snow White**

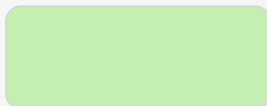
#F6F6F6

**White**

#FFFFFF

**Violet**

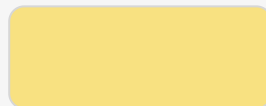
#B9BBF4

**Lime Green**

#C5EEB3

**Ocean Blue**

#4B7BC3

**Yellow**

#F8E181

**Pink**

#F3B0B0

White is not in the original guide. It is listed because cards and panels sit on it, and a ground that carries text has to be an approved half of a pair.

FUNCTIONAL

**Hover Green**

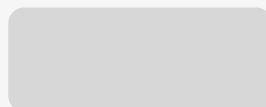
#98DE7E

The hover and focus state of the primary button.

**Muted Grey**

#6B6B6B

Secondary text: dates, captions, metadata.

**Hairline Grey**

#D7D7D7

Hairline rules, and the border of an unchecked control.

**Error Red**

#CF1322

Form error messages.

Muted Grey is set where it clears 4.5:1 on both White and Snow White; a lighter grey does not, however good it looks. The original guide states CMYK values alongside each colour, but they do not match a standard conversion from the same hex and name no profile, so they are not reproduced — get CMYK from your printer against a named profile.

Colours are approved in pairs

A pair not in this table is not approved. Each sample is the pair itself.

Pair	Foreground on background	Ratio	Use for
Aa	Night Blue on Snow White	15.60	Page ground and all long-form reading.
Aa	Night Blue on White	16.85	Cards and panels lifted off the ground.
Aa	Snow White on Night Blue	15.60	Inverted sections, the footer, dark buttons.
Aa	Night Blue on Lime Green	13.05	The primary button.
Aa	Night Blue on Hover Green	10.50	The primary button, hover and focus.
Aa	Night Blue on Yellow	12.90	Section grounds and cards.
Aa	Night Blue on Pink	9.35	Section grounds and cards.
Aa	Night Blue on Violet	9.21	Section grounds and callouts.
Aa	Muted Grey on White	5.33	Secondary text on a card.
Aa	Muted Grey on Snow White	4.93	Secondary text on the page ground.
Aa	Error Red on White	5.57	Form error messages on a card.
Aa	Error Red on Snow White	5.16	Form error messages on the page ground.
Aa	Ocean Blue on White	4.27	Display text at 24px and above. Never body text.
Aa	Ocean Blue on Snow White	3.95	The same, on the page ground.
—	Hairline Grey on White	1.44	Hairline rules only. Never text.
—	Hairline Grey on Snow White	1.33	The same, on the page ground.

Four things the palette does not do

Ocean Blue as body text

4.27:1 on White, 3.95:1 on Snow White. It is a details colour: large display text, icons and rules. The website uses it as the link hover colour at 18px, which fails; links hover to Night Blue instead.

Ocean Blue as a background

Night Blue on it is 3.95:1 and Snow White on it is 3.95:1. There is no readable text colour for that ground, so it is never a ground.

The four pastels as text

Violet, Lime Green, Yellow and Pink are grounds and details. Night Blue is the only foreground approved on any of them.

Any pair not in the table

Including pastel on pastel, and any of the greys on a pastel.

Not every approved pair carries a mark

Nine of the sixteen pairs are also approved for the logotype and the icon logo. A pair approved for secondary text, form errors or hairline rules is approved for that, and a mark is none of those things. The nine are on page 14.

The original guide holds two colour tables that overlap and disagree. Ocean Blue is tagged *Details* in one and *Backgrounds, Details* in the other; the package resolves that as details only, on the contrast evidence. The guide also instructs "Dark Mode: use Grey for titles & body text" while defining no colour called Grey. That instruction is not carried over.

Two faces, used in very unequal measure

DISPLAY

Voyage

--font-display: Voyage, Georgia, "Times New Roman", serif. Regular only — no italic, no variable axis, one weight. Below about 24px it loses its detail and reads as a generic serif, so it never sets anything small.

BODY

General Sans

--font-body: "General Sans", "Helvetica Neue", Helvetica, Arial, sans-serif. A variable font: one file per style spanning weight 200 to 700, upright and italic.

Both faces ship in the package as woff2 and are self-hosted. Never a link or an import to Google Fonts, Fontshare or any other third-party host: Aardling's typography does not depend on a network it does not control.

Letter-spacing

None, at any size, in either face, with one exception: uppercase labels take 0.12em to 0.14em, because capitals set at their default fit are too tight to read. The eyebrow at the top of this page is one.

Wrapping

Headings, taglines, pull quotes, buttons and captions are balanced across their lines rather than left with a single orphaned word. Body copy is set to avoid orphans. Protected terms never break — see page 21.

Six weights, upright and italic

General Sans covers 200 to 700 in one variable file per style, so every weight below is available without loading a file per cut. Voyage is Regular only.

200 Extralight	Very large display settings only
300 Light	Large introductory paragraphs
400 Regular	Body copy, buttons, captions — the default
500 Medium	Headings, everywhere
600 Semibold	Emphasis in running text, table headers
700 Bold	Rare — only where 600 fails to separate

Headings are **500**. Use `--font-weight-heading` rather than the literal, so the decision lives in one place. The website's stylesheet has asked for 500 since it was built and silently rendered 400, because only two cuts were loaded; the Medium cut is in the package now and the original intent stands.

Italics

400 Regular italic	<i>The title of a work</i>
500 Medium italic	<i>A term being introduced</i>
600 Semibold italic	<i>A genuine aside</i>

Italics exist at every weight. Use them for what italics are for. Not for emphasis; that is what 600 is for.

Eight steps

Base sizes, at 960px and above, shown at size. Every heading step drops to 0.8 below 960px, which is the step this page is set at: an A4 sheet at 96dpi is 794px wide.

h1 55 / 1.2	Aardling
h2 45 / 1.2	Aardling
h3 35 / 1.2	Aardling
h4 30 / 1.2	Aardling
h5 25 / 1.2	Aardling
h6 22 / 1.3	Aardling
body 18 / 1.5	Aardling
small 14 / 1.5	Aardling

The scale moves at three breakpoints

Step	Below 960	Base	From 1728	From 1920
h1	44	55	61	66
h2	36	45	50	54
h3	28	35	39	42
h4	24	30	33	36
h5	20	25	28	30
h6	18	22	24	26
body	18	18	20	22
small	14	14	15	17

Voyage holds a phrase, not a paragraph

Voyage is used sparingly — typically once on a page, on one short title. Normally that is the h1: the page hero, or the one heading a reader is meant to carry away. A second Voyage setting on the same page is an exception and needs a reason.

Everything else is General Sans, including headings that look like they want the display face: h2 and h3, card titles, call-to-action headings, pull quotes, form section labels, table captions, sidebar headers. A page set almost entirely in General Sans is the normal case, not a compromise.

Keep the Voyage title short — one line, a handful of words. The face has one weight, no italic and no variable axis. Below about 24px it never sets anything at all: if a title needs to be smaller than that, it is not the Voyage title on that page.

Voyage never sets a heading on artwork

A heading placed on a gradient is General Sans at the heading weight, whatever its size. Voyage's hairlines and its thick-to-thin contrast are exactly what the gradients' grain interferes with. It is the same interference that sets the marks' minimum sizes on a gradient. See page 16.

Every Voyage setting in this document is a page title, one per page — the single exception being the specimen on page 8, which is the face shown as itself. The subheads, the tables and this paragraph are all General Sans.

Two marks, one measure of air

The logotype is 623 × 131 units; the icon logo is 167 × 107. Both are transparent and filled with **currentColor** — set **color** on the parent and the mark follows. The icon logo is the double-A ligature cut from the logotype's own outline, and it sits inside the logotype at 1:1.

Clear space on all four sides is the height of the icon logo: 106 units



That measure is not arbitrary and it is not two measures. The icon logo's ink is 106.25 units tall in both drawings, so one number serves both marks. On the logotype, 106 units is 81% of the mark's own height. That is deliberate: cramped is the failure that keeps happening, and nobody has ever complained that an Ardling mark had too much room.

Mark	Mark size	Lockup canvas
Logotype	623 × 131	835 × 343
Icon logo	167 × 107	379 × 379

The icon canvas is squared so one file serves an avatar upload without recropping. Squaring only adds air: the horizontal clear space is exactly 106, the vertical 136. Lockups — the mark, its ground and its clear space flattened into one fixed-size file — are for the places that cannot supply a ground or set **color**. They are generated from the two masters and never edited by hand.

The floors, shown at size

AARDLING

Logotype: 96px mark, 129px lockup



Icon logo: 16px mark, 36px lockup

Mark	On a flat ground	On a gradient
Logotype	96px mark, 129px lockup	380px lockup
Icon logo	16px mark, 36px lockup	64px lockup

A gradient costs roughly three times the floor a flat ground does, and the reason is the grain rather than the contrast. Below those widths, use a flat approved ground.

Ocean Blue needs more room than the rest

The palette allows Ocean Blue for display text at 24px and above. The logotype's cap height is 106 of its 131 units, so a 96px-wide logotype has a 16px cap — under that threshold. The two rules would contradict each other if left alone.

An Ocean Blue logotype is never narrower than 141px, a 189px lockup. That is the width at which its cap height reaches 24px. It is not drawn on the icon logo at all, which floors at 16px and never gets near.

This is the one colourway whose minimum differs from the mark's own. Ocean Blue is a details colour and the logotype is drawn in hairlines; 4.27:1 on White behaves worse than the number suggests when the strokes are that thin.

The logotype is for big touchpoints — a site header, a slide, a social post, anywhere the name should be read. The icon logo is for small ones — a favicon, an avatar, a thumbnail — and for anywhere the logotype would be illegible.

Nine colourways

Both marks take all nine, except the two Ocean Blue pairs, which are the logotype only. Shown at 170px; each chip's padding is the mark's own clear space.

Night Blue on Snow White

Night Blue on White

Snow White on Night Blue

Night Blue on Lime Green

Night Blue on Yellow

Night Blue on Pink

Night Blue on Violet

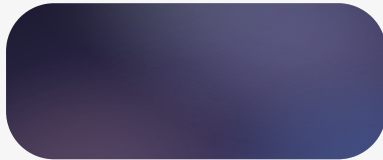
Ocean Blue on White — logotype only, never under 141px

Ocean Blue on Snow White — logotype only, never under 141px

The other seven approved pairs carry no mark. A greyed mark reads as disabled, a red one as a failure, a Hairline Grey one is invisible at 1.44:1, and a mark has no hover state.

Four gradients

SVG, a few kilobytes each, sharp at any size. Two dark, two light. Each is authored at 1600 × 1000 and crops to fill any box without distorting.



Vesper

Near-black to a deep violet, a Pink glow low left, Ocean Blue holding the far corner. The quiet dark one: behind a slide of content, or a section band that must not compete. **No grain** — with it, white falls from 6.57:1 to 5.20:1.



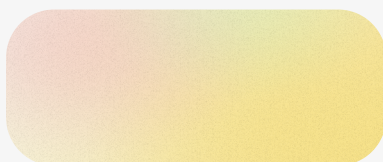
Understory

The darkest field in the brand: Ocean Blue at one corner, Lime Green at the other, near-black between them. The dark one meant to be looked at — a cover, or a full-bleed ground. It competes, deliberately. **No grain:** with it, white drops to 4.60:1, under the floor.



Bloom

Snow White into Violet, with Lime Green and Pink blooms. The light option, and the only one that takes Night Blue text-adjacent panels well. Carries grain, drawn as an SVG filter rather than a baked-in texture.



Harvest

Snow White into Yellow, with a second Yellow bloom low, Pink opposite, and a Lime Green highlight. The warm option: social cards, event artwork, a title slide. Carries grain.

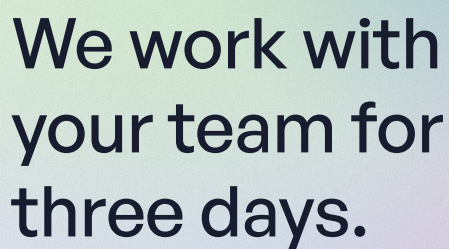
Each one sits at one end of the luminance range, and stays there. That is what lets a single knocked-out colour separate cleanly from the whole field rather than only from part of it. A gradient whose ramp spans the range takes no mark at all, and the warm gradient that preceded Harvest was withdrawn for exactly that reason.

They are **artwork, not colour**. Never sample a pixel into the palette and never recolour one ad hoc — a new colourway gets drawn and added.

A mark, or one heading. Never both.



Either mark, knocked out: White on Vesper and Understory, Night Blue on Bloom and Harvest. Measured under the mark's own ink — Vesper 7.09:1 at worst, Understory 7.00:1, Bloom 8.08:1, Harvest 10.33:1.



Or one heading, in the same colour the knocked-out mark takes on that ground, so a gradient never carries two lettering colours.

Constraint	Why
The body face, never Voyage.	Voyage's thick-to-thin contrast and hairline serifs lose to the grain.
35px or larger.	Comfortably past the large-text threshold, with margin for the grain.
At most half the width, on the gradient's steadiest side — upper right on Vesper, lower left on Understory, right of centre on Bloom, lower right on Harvest.	Full width across the middle, a heading runs 6.65:1 to 16.25:1 on Vesper and 5.87:1 to 17.33:1 on Understory, and visibly shifts weight along the line. Inside the steady region it swings 2.91 and 3.88. Width alone is not enough: Understory's right half still swings 10.41.
Two or three lines, balanced.	A heading is a phrase held inside one region of the artwork, not a line crossing it.

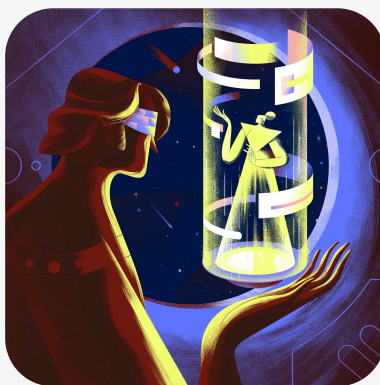
Nothing else goes on top. No body copy, no captions, no labels, no lists, no buttons — and no scrim or blur anywhere, on anything.

Illustrations take no text at all

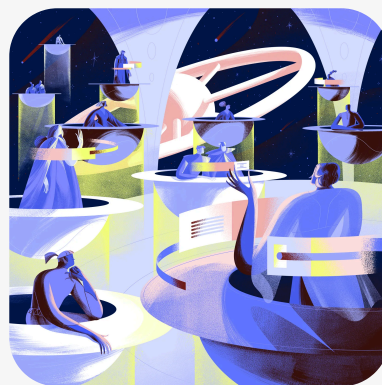
Not a heading, not a caption. The licence on the previous page is for gradients only, because a gradient is a controlled field with a measured luminance band and an illustration is not. Text goes beside an illustration, or on a solid panel next to it.



A workshop in progress



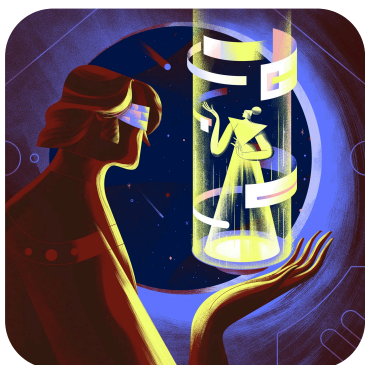
One-to-one coaching



A conference or event

These are painterly and stay raster — the exception the SVG-by-default rule exists for. The package ships them at 1600px as WebP with a PNG beside each.

YES — TEXT BESIDE THE IMAGE



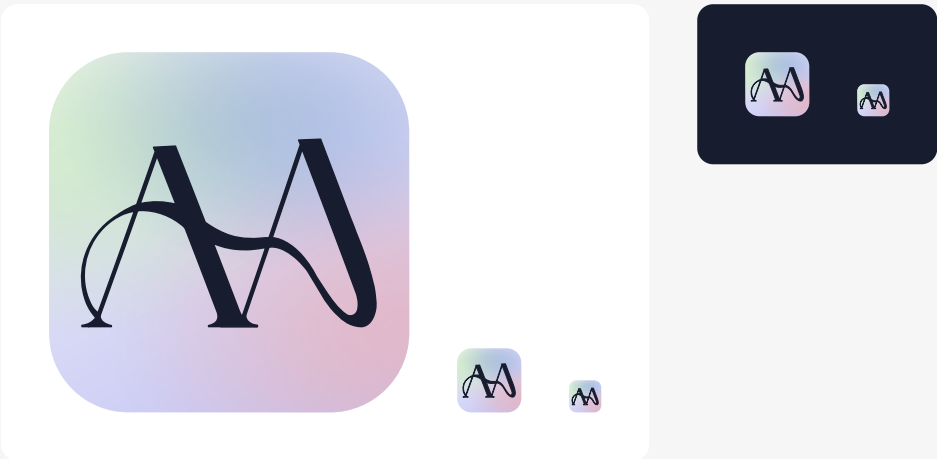
One-to-one coaching

The image keeps its own frame and the words keep theirs. Nothing is set over the artwork, and nothing needs a scrim to stay readable. The alternatives, in order of preference: text beside the image; text on a solid panel adjacent to it; the image reduced to an accent.

The full-resolution masters — 5000 × 5000, plus CMYK TIFFs for print — are in the **Aardling — Brand** shared Google Drive. The package carries the versions meant for building things; Drive carries the originals.

The icon logo, knocked out of Bloom

Night Blue on a rounded tile cut from `gradient-bloom.svg`. `favicon.svg` is the source; every raster is generated from it. Shown at 180, 32 and 16 pixels, on both grounds a tab strip offers.



Decision	Value	Why
Crop	The gradient's own centre square	No bespoke framing. A tighter crop raises contrast but lands in the Lime Green bloom, and the tile goes mint.
Corner radius	22% of the tile	The radius tokens are absolute and do not transfer to a drawing rendered from 16 to 512px. 22% is what iOS, Android and macOS use.
Mark size	82% of the tile width	At 74% the hairlines fall below one pixel at 16px and drop out.
Mark stroke	0.8 units, in the mark's own colour	Thickens the hairlines symmetrically without redrawing the letterform.

The favicon drops Bloom's grain. Below about 64px the filter is sampled far under its own frequency and lands as coloured blotch fighting the mark. That licence is narrow: a generated derivative at fixed small sizes is not a reproduction of the gradient, and Bloom and Harvest keep their grain wherever they are shown as themselves.

A favicon change ships the whole set: `favicon.svg`, `favicon.ico` with 16 and 32 embedded, `apple-touch-icon.png` at 180, `icon-192.png` and `icon-512.png`.

Spacing is specified, never implied

The scale is 8px steps. Nine are published, every one has a job, and each is shown here at size.

--space-1	8px	
--space-2	16px	
--space-3	24px	
--space-4	32px	
--space-6	48px	
--space-8	64px	
--space-10	80px	
--space-12	96px	
--space-18	144px	

--space-1	Gap inside a control: between an icon and its label.
-----------	--

--space-2	Gap between closely related things: a label and its field, items in a list.
-----------	---

--space-3	Grid gutter up to 1400px. Paragraph rhythm in running prose.
-----------	--

--space-4	Grid gutter above 1400px. Padding inside a card.
-----------	--

--space-6	Vertical padding of a coloured section, below 720px.
-----------	--

--space-8	Top and bottom of a hero, below 960px.
-----------	--

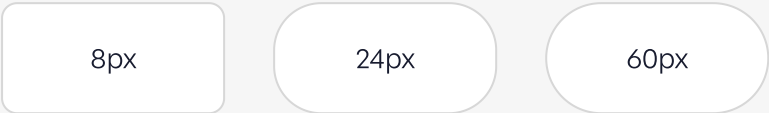
--space-10	Vertical padding of a coloured section, from 720px.
------------	---

--space-12	Vertical padding of a coloured section, from 960px.
------------	---

--space-18	Top of a detail-page hero, from 960px.
------------	--

Prefer the larger step when two look plausible. Lay sibling groups out with flex or grid and gap — not margins on children, and not whitespace in the source.

Three radii, and no more



`--radius-sm` for tooltips, tags and swatches; `--radius-md` for cards, panels and image containers; `--radius-pill` for buttons and pills.

The button



`--space-1` gap, 12px vertical and 24px horizontal padding, pill radius, never less than 44px high — a minimum for anything tappable, not a target to design down to.

Breakpoints and containers

Step	Breakpoint	Container
sm	540px	516px
md	720px	696px
lg	960px	936px
xl	1140px	1116px
xxl	1400px	1312px
xxxl	1728px	1504px
mega	1920px	1696px

Page side margins are 28px below 540px, and the container gutter above it.

A protected term sits on one line

Every break opportunity inside it is suppressed, at spaces and at hyphens alike. "Domain-Driven Design" is one concept and has to look like one.

NO

**Scaling Domain-
Driven Design to 800
engineers**

YES

**Scaling
Domain-Driven Design
to 800 engineers**

Domain-Driven Design · EventStorming · Event Sourcing · Team Topologies ·
Data Mesh · Aardling

In markup, wrap the whole term in a single span with **white-space: nowrap** — one span covers the spaces and the hyphens at once. In plain text, use a non-breaking space between the words *and* a non-breaking hyphen, but prefer the span wherever markup exists: U+2011 is missing from many fonts, Voyage included. If a term does not fit the line, the line is wrong, not the term.

Never text on top of an image

Not over photographs, not over illustrations, and not with a scrim, a blur or a gradient overlay to rescue it. The alternatives, in order of preference: text beside the image; text on a solid panel adjacent to it; the image reduced to an accent.

The current website breaks this — the default hero sets the h1 over a cover photograph — and so do several mockups in the original brand guide. Those layouts are wrong and change; the rule does not bend for them.

The single exception is the gradient licence on page 16, and it is narrow: a gradient is a measured field, an illustration is not.

We, not I, and never an institution

Aardling is a group of consultants, and the writing says so. Not "I" — that belongs to a personal blog. Not "Aardling provides", which turns a room full of people into an institution issuing statements. Name the people where naming them helps: "Gien ran the EventStorming session" beats "a consultant facilitated the session".

Register

Expert, plain, unhurried. Our readers are tech leaders in finance, logistics, government, media and biotech. Much of what we write gets forwarded to someone who controls a budget; write so that both can read it.

British English

Not just the spelling — modelling, organisation, analyse, recognise, prioritise, licence as a noun — but the vocabulary that goes with it.

Proper nouns split two ways

Places take their English name, where one exists. Antwerp, not Antwerpen. Brussels, The Hague, Cologne. Most places have no English name and are left as they are: Hoorn, Lille. Never invent one.

Companies and people keep their own spelling. Never anglicised, never stripped of accents. Société Générale, not Societe Generale.

Say what the work is. We run workshops, model domains, review architectures, teach courses, and sit with teams for weeks. Every one of those happened on a date. Prefer it to the category it belongs to.

Our vocabulary, without assuming the reader shares it

Domain-Driven Design, EventStorming, Event Sourcing, bounded contexts, Team Topologies — our terms, used without apology. But the reader may not share our background, so a term earns its place by being either explained in passing or unnecessary. Nothing that assumes the reader was in the room.

YES

We mapped the bounded contexts — the boundaries inside which a model holds — and found three places where two teams owned the same concept.

NO

We applied strategic DDD to surface context boundary misalignment.

No hype

Not exciting, not revolutionary, not game-changing, not a journey, not future-proof. If a sentence would survive being pasted into any other consultancy's website, it is not about us.

NO

In a world full of concrete, Aardling is the tree that grows with you.

YES

We help you make sense of complex environments. Through models, we guide your software design strategy and untangle organisational constraints.

The original brand guide carries a manifesto and four values written in a register this brand rejects. Their substance is kept; the register is not.

Active, short, and backed

No unbacked claims

No superlatives, no numbers without a source, no promises nobody has thought through. "We trained about 800 engineers at Shopify" is a fact with a case study behind it. "The go-to technology consultants" is not a fact at all.

No filler

If a sentence can be deleted and nothing is lost, delete it. No throat-clearing before the point, no restating what was just said in different words.

Sentences

Active voice. Short sentences. A verb where a nominalisation tempts.

NO

Comprehensive delivery of transformational value is provided across the engagement.

YES

We work with your team for three days and leave you with a model you can use.

THE ONE APPROVED TAGLINE

Software strategy, architecture, and domain modelling in complex environments.

Use it verbatim, or do not use one. It carries a serial comma. That is the approved wording and it is not corrected to house style, here or anywhere it is reproduced.

The package is the source of truth

Generated from [@aardling/brand-aardling](#) at version 0.8.0. Where this printed page condenses, the file in the package is the longer answer.

Path	Contents
tokens/	Design tokens as data, and the same tokens as CSS custom properties.
guidelines/colour.md	The palette, the accepted pairs, and what each is for.
guidelines/typography.md	The two faces, the scale, and the weights.
guidelines/layout.md	Spacing, radii, and the protected terms.
guidelines/imagery.md	Gradients and illustrations, and what may sit on them.
guidelines/logos.md	Masters, lockups, clear space, minimum sizes.
guidelines/naming.md	The brand name and the company names.
guidelines/voice.md	Register, person, and do/don't examples.
assets/logos/	The logotype and the icon logo, both SVG, both <code>currentColor</code> .
assets/logos/lockups/	22 flattened mark-on-ground files, generated from the masters.
assets/icons/	The 18-mark icon set, SVG, <code>currentColor</code> .
assets/favicons/	The favicon source and its rasters.
assets/fonts/	Both faces as <code>woff2</code> , plus the <code>@font-face</code> declarations.
assets/images/	Four gradients, and three illustrations.
skills/aardling-brand/	A skill teaching agents to apply this brand.

npm install @aardling/brand-aardling

Published to GitHub Packages, not the public npm registry: the consuming project needs an `.npmrc` pointing the `@aardling` scope at [npm.pkg.github.com](#), and a token with `read:packages`.